

February

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	Full Moon	New Moon
2008	February 21	February 7
2009	February 9	February 25
2010	February 28	February 14
2011	February 18	February 3
2012	February 7	February 21

ECLIPSES

2008: February 7 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from Antarctica. A partial solar eclipse is visible from New Zealand and southeastern Australia.

2008: February 21 A total eclipse of the Moon is visible from western Europe, Africa, and North and South America.

THE PLANETS

2008: February 1
Venus and Jupiter appear about a Moon-width apart in the eastern dawn sky.

2008: February 24
Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.2. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

2008: February 27
Mercury and Venus appear about two Moon-widths apart in the eastern dawn sky.

2009: February 13
Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.0.

2009: February 17–18
Jupiter and Mars appear about a Moon-width apart in the eastern dawn sky.

2009: February 24
Jupiter and Mercury appear about a Moon-width apart in the eastern dawn sky.

Opposition and **elongation** are explained on *page 14*

A triangle of bright stars and a pair of twins shine high in February's sky. The equilateral triangle is made by linking three stars in different constellations. They are Betelgeuse in Orion's shoulder, and Sirius and Procyon, the bright stars in each of Orion's two dogs, Canis Major and Canis Minor. The twins Castor and Pollux are represented by the bright stars of the same name.



Beehive Cluster

Also known as Praesepe, or M44, the Beehive Cluster is in Cancer, seen high to the south this month. The brightest stars in this open cluster of 350 or so stars are magnitude 6, making it visible to the naked eye as a cloudy patch. Binoculars show it as a star field of more than three apparent Moon-widths.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

The triangle of stars formed by Betelgeuse, Sirius, and Procyon is known as the Winter Triangle (see pp.20–21). Sirius and Procyon are easy to spot to the south, since they are the first- and eighth-brightest stars. Brilliant Sirius is closest to the southern horizon; Procyon is above, to Sirius's left. Betelgeuse is in the constellation of Orion, above and to the right of Sirius.

Beyond Orion, and in the southwestern sky, is Taurus, the bull. The distinctive shape of Leo, the lion, is now in view in the southeast, and Gemini is almost overhead. The twins are nearly parallel to the horizon, with their heads pointing to Leo and their feet toward Taurus.

Capella, the bright star in Auriga, is high in the western sky. Below is Perseus, the mythological hero who rescued Andromeda from a sea monster. The chained figure of Andromeda is between Perseus and the horizon. Her mother, Cassiopeia, is to her right in the northwestern sky. The two other circumpolar constellations, Ursa Major and Ursa Minor, are to the northeast.

